Scenario 2 Sociocultural Data Biography (SDB): Legacy of Slavery Domestic Traffic Ads Sample

1. Contextual Adequacy — Systemic Contextual Analysis

(1) Record-Generating Purpose and Institutional Mandate Within the provided sample, the primary commercial function of the advertisements was to facilitate the sale, purchase, or hiring of enslaved individuals, or to satisfy legal and estate debts through public auction. This institutional mandate determined exactly what was emphasized or omitted: records prioritize physical attributes, skills, and legal terms of enslavement (e.g., "stout healthy NEGRO MAN," "slave for life") that maximized market value or satisfied legal requirements, while systematically omitting the lived histories and full identities of the enslaved individuals.

(2) Socio-Legal Structures The sample reflects antebellum Maryland's socio-legal structures, which legally classified enslaved people as property subject to commercial exchange, estate liquidation, and debt seizure. This is evidenced by ads generated for "Sheriff's Sale" to satisfy lawsuits or estate debts, and frequent references to specific Maryland legal conditions such as "term of years" versus "slave for life" or stipulations that the individuals "not be sold out of the state".

(3) Actors, Perspectives, and Authority The authorial locus of this dataset is firmly situated within the **Subscriber Firstname**, **Subscriber Lastname**, **Subscriber Locale**, and **Subscriber State** fields, representing the enslavers, public dealers, sheriffs, and agents who authored the records. Because this commercial class held total narrative authority, the perspectives, voices, and agency of the enslaved people themselves are entirely excluded from the corpus.

(4) Representational Conventions The corpus relies on historically situated, commodifying, and racialized descriptive language rather than objective fact. The **FULL TEXT** and **Skills Specified** fields deploy conventions like "valuable servants," "first rate farm hand," or "likely negro GIRL" to signal physical utility and economic worth. The **Age Specified** field is similarly positioned as a metric of remaining labor capacity rather than a reliable demographic data point.

(5) Spatial and Temporal Variation *Spatial:* Across the sample, transaction types and record practices vary across Maryland counties (captured in **County**, **Sale Location County**, **Sale Location Locale**, and **Sale Location State**). For instance, public Sheriff's Sales frequently detail specific local taverns or courthouses in Dorchester or Queen Anne's counties, whereas private sales are often centralized in Baltimore City offices. *Temporal:* There is observable variation in the temporal fields (**Ad Date**, **Press Date**, and **Sale Date**). Where **Sale Date** is populated, it consistently follows the **Ad Date** and **Press Date**, reflecting a scheduled future event. In cases where **Ad Date** and **Press Date** differ (e.g., **Ad Date** 18300529 and **Press Date** 18301113), it remains an open interpretive question whether the ad ran continuously for months or if the dates represent separate record-keeping artifacts; the underlying meaning cannot be definitively resolved from this sample without speculative assumptions.

(6) Structured Absences, Silences, and Uncertainties *Accidental/Practical Absences:* Missing values in fields like **Press Date** or **Source Page** occasionally appear as practical omissions in the transcription or printing process. *Structural Absences:* The **First Name** and **Last Name** fields are systematically absent or reduced to a single moniker (e.g., "Lucy," "Ned") due to the structural mechanism of commodification, which stripped enslaved people of identifiable personhood. Similarly, the **Sale Date** and **Sale Disposition** fields are structurally absent in private "Wanted" or "For Sale" advertisements, as the transaction was an open-ended offer rather than a legally scheduled public event. *Intersection Account:* The intersection of Maryland's legal mandate for property seizure (Dimension 1 & 2) and the structural silence of anonymization (Dimension 6) produces a distinct data feature: the **First Name** field is most frequently populated in "Sheriff's Sale" or public estate records, where the legal system required a specific identification of the seized "property" for debt resolution (e.g., "Jacob," "Rachel"), whereas private sale ads rely almost entirely on nameless physical descriptions in the **FULL TEXT** field.

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2. Evidentiary Adequacy — Source Material Domain Evaluation

(1) Traceability Every contextual claim is traceable to the primary corpus (Notebook 1). The structural absence of **Sale Date** in private sales is proven by rows where **Ad Type** is "buy" or "sell" and **Sale Disposition** is "private_dealer" (e.g., Lewis F. Scotti's agency ads), which systematically lack a **Sale Date**. The legal mandate of property seizure is traced directly to rows where **Ad Type** is "Sale" and **Sale Disposition** is "public_dealer," which include explicit **Notes** about debt satisfaction.

(2) Transparency of Reasoning The evidence directly supports the claims. For example, the claim that **Sale Date** absences are structural rather than accidental is supported by comparing public and private ads: public Sheriff's ads consistently feature a future **Sale Date** (e.g., **Press Date** 18280726 vs **Sale Date** 18280812) because auctions were scheduled events, whereas private "For Sale" ads leave the field blank because they represent a continuous market availability.

(3) Uncertainty Acknowledgment It must be explicitly acknowledged that fields such as **Age Specified** (e.g., "about 25 years of age," "12 to 25") and **Skills Specified** (e.g., "first rate manager") reflect the advertiser's estimation and strategic misrepresentation to maximize commercial appeal. Any computational claims derived from these fields must be qualified as reflections of market demand rather than verified historical or demographic facts. *Citation Specificity Note:* No scholarly context notebook (Notebook 2) was provided for this scenario; therefore, all evidence is strictly derived from the primary dataset, and no external scholarly citations are asserted, explicitly complying with the boundary limitation.

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3. Translational Adequacy — Data Pre-Processing and Analytical Design Guidance

(1) Data Preparation and Representation When preprocessing this dataset, the commodifying language in **FULL TEXT** and **Skills Specified** (e.g., "valuable servants," "stout") must not be normalized, standardized, or "cleaned" out of the text, as doing so would obscure the historical reality of the commercial violence enacted by the authors. Furthermore, missing values in **Sale Date** and **Sale Disposition** for private market ads should be encoded as an analytically meaningful category (e.g., "Unscheduled/Open Market") rather than imputed or treated as errors to correct, as the absence itself signifies a distinct transaction type.

(2) Concept Operationalization To computationally operationalize the concept of "labor commodification," algorithms cannot rely solely on the structured **Skills Specified** field, which is frequently blank or limited. Instead, operationalization must directly address the unstructured text in **FULL TEXT** by extracting historically contingent descriptive clusters (e.g., age estimations paired with terms like "healthy," "for life," or "term of years") to capture how human life was translated into market value.

(3) Analytical Design Given the conditions of the corpus, attempting *entity resolution* or individual-level genealogical reconstruction is an inappropriate and unreliable category of analysis. The systemic anonymization of the enslaved in the **First Name** and **Last Name** fields, combined with the fungible descriptions in the **FULL TEXT**, is a historical limitation of the archive's violent record-generating process, not a fixable data-quality issue.

(4) Method and Algorithm Selection Any method applied to measure "labor demand" or "commodification" (such as topic modeling or sentiment analysis) is strictly bounded by the Subscriber-centric perspective of the corpus. Algorithms will only model the white commercial class's marketing strategies, economic anxieties, and legal vocabulary—they cannot be interpreted as modeling the actual demographics, skills, or lived realities of the enslaved population.

Ambiguity Clause: There is genuine ambiguity regarding the computational treatment of discrepancies between **Ad Date** and **Press Date** (e.g., where the dates are months apart). It is defensible to either encode the **Press Date** as the primary temporal marker of the record's public circulation or to use the **Ad Date** as the moment of authorial intent. Acknowledging this ambiguity is necessary, as either choice shifts the temporal timeline of the analysis without a definitive historical resolution available in the sample.

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4. Analytical Utility — Interpretive Guidance for the Research Lifecycle

This biography serves as an interpretive resource for evaluating computational outputs generated from this dataset.

Retrospective Illustration: For example, if a researcher explicitly observed a hypothetical computational output where a clustering algorithm revealed that the **Age Specified** field was heavily skewed toward tight ranges (e.g., exclusively clustering around ages 14–25) and strongly correlated with the word "healthy" in the **FULL TEXT**, the documented sociocultural conditions would guide the interpretation. The researcher should not interpret this as a demographic finding that only young, healthy people were enslaved. Rather, using this biography, they would recognize this distributional anomaly as an artifact of the record-generating process: subscribers strategically estimated ages and utilized specific rhetorical formulas to target peak market demand for prime labor.

Unanswerable Questions: As established, the corpus cannot reliably answer historical questions concerning family lineages, kinship structures, or the individual biographies of the enslaved persons. This limitation is historically grounded in the commercial mandate of the ads, which purposely ruptured and silenced individual identity to facilitate seamless property transfer.

Guidance for Inherited Biases & Meaningful Patterns: When interpreting findings, researchers must account for the commercial perspective of the **Subscriber** fields. Any "patterns" of missing data in **Sale Date** are artifacts of private market conventions, while geographic spikes in public sales may represent historically meaningful patterns of regional debt crises or estate liquidations. Researchers must consistently distinguish between the reality of the antebellum slave trade and the highly curated, legally sanitized, and economically driven representation of it preserved in these advertisements.